

RESEARCH STATEMENT

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I am an applied microeconomist with research interests spanning family economics, labor economics, health economics, and development economics. A common thread across my work is the study of how disadvantage propagates across generations: how the circumstances into which children are born, and the behaviors of the adults who raise them, shape outcomes in education, health, and economic life. My research draws on a range of methods – dynamic structural modeling, quasi-experimental methods, and reduced-form causal designs – to generate credible evidence that can inform policy at the federal, state, and international levels. My work spans the United States and Sub-Saharan Africa, and engages questions relevant to families at the lower end of the income distribution in both contexts.

My Dissertation

The centerpiece of my research agenda is my dissertation, *From Cradle to Consequence: The Dynamic Impact of Parental Behaviors on Teenage Outcomes Among Fragile Families*. Fragile families – children born to disadvantaged, often unmarried mothers who are disproportionately racial minorities with limited education and income – represent a large and persistently understudied population. Since 2007, over 40 percent of children born each year in the United States are born to unmarried women, and approximately 50 percent of fathers in fragile families carry at least one major risk factor, including substance use disorder, physical abuse, or incarceration. Yet the literature has largely studied the behaviors of these parents in isolation, one behavior at a time and at a single point in time, despite the fact that marital, employment, welfare, substance use, and criminal decisions are made jointly and evolve dynamically across a child's entire developmental lifecycle. Studies that treat these behaviors separately risk omitted variable bias, because each behavior is confounded by all the others that parents make simultaneously.

I address this gap by developing and jointly estimating a dynamic model of parental behaviors, child cognitive skill formation, and teenage outcome production using the Discrete Factor Random Effects (DFRE) methodology and six waves of the Future of Families and Child Wellbeing Study (FFCWS). The model spans birth through age 15 and allows parental behaviors and child cognitive skill to evolve continuously over childhood, with teenage outcomes realized at the end of the developmental lifecycle, while explicitly accounting for permanent and time-varying family unobserved heterogeneity throughout, enabling credible causal identification.

The results show that the timing and persistence of parental behaviors matter enormously for adolescent outcomes, and that the effects of stable, positive parenting environments are consistently larger than those of any single behavior studied in isolation. Stable biological father presence improves educational outcomes, while persistent welfare receipt and parental criminal involvement are among the strongest predictors of adolescent delinquency. When all parental behaviors are deteriorated jointly, the damage to teenage outcomes is larger than the sum of individual effects – reflecting nonlinear compounding that only a joint model can uncover, and providing direct empirical support for the view that family disadvantage operates as a bundle rather than a collection of independent risks. Three policy experiments illustrate the implications: a Sin-to-Skill excise tax reinvesting revenue in school quality, a biological-father cohabitation promotion policy, and a mandatory parental leave policy each generate distinct and sometimes counter-intuitive effects, underscoring the importance of modeling behavioral interdependencies before designing family-targeted interventions.

Other Papers and Works in Progress

My research extends beyond the dissertation into several substantive areas that reflect my broader interests in family, education, labor, health and development economics.

Social safety net, poverty, and human capital. In *Cash Transfer and Multidimensional Child Poverty: Evidence from Ghana*, I examine the impact of Ghana’s Livelihood Empowerment Against Poverty (LEAP) program on multidimensional child poverty using a DiD and propensity score matching design. LEAP recipients experience significant reductions in poverty, with the largest gains in health and education dimensions. In a related working paper, *Cash Transfer and the Labor Supply of Vulnerable Households: Does Household Indebtedness Matter?*, we find that indebtedness significantly moderates the labor supply response to transfers, with indebted households more likely to channel transfers toward debt repayment – an important consideration for transfer program design in contexts where informal credit markets are prevalent. A connected manuscript, *The Causal Effects of Multidimensional School and Household Poverty on Student Achievement: An IV-Latent Class Analysis*, uses IV+LCA to show that household poverty exerts a robust negative effect on Mathematics and English scores among public school students, while school poverty loses significance once student composition is accounted for – making the case for redirecting education policy attention toward household support rather than school infrastructure alone.

Substance use and health systems. In *Impact of Alcohol Use on Academic Performance Among College Students*, I exploit within-student variation to distinguish between heavy episodic and chronic drinking, finding that chronic consumption has a persistent negative effect on GPA while acute effects are largely transitory. This paper complements my dissertation’s analysis of how substance use in the parental generation transmits to teenage substance use in the child generation. In a manuscript in preparation, *Rural Hospital Closures and Hospital Surge Capacity*, we examine how the recent wave of rural hospital closures has eroded regional health system capacity to absorb demand shocks from natural disasters, disease outbreaks, and mass casualty events – reflecting my broader interest in how structural features of the healthcare system generate inequities in access for rural and low-income populations.

Maternal investments and child health. In *Maternal Education and Child Malnutrition: Evidence from West Africa*, we find robust negative effects of maternal education on child stunting and underweight, with larger effects at higher attainment levels. In *Implication of Natal Care and Maternity Leave on Child Morbidity*, both prenatal care utilization and longer leave durations significantly reduce child illness in early life – consistent with the mechanism in my dissertation’s parental leave experiment. These papers establish that maternal education, health behaviors during pregnancy, and time at home after birth are among the most powerful levers for improving child health and human capital in resource-constrained settings.

Future Research

My future research agenda has three interconnected strands. The first extends my dissertation framework. Looking further ahead, the FFCWS is an ongoing study that now follows respondents into adulthood – the most recent wave extends to age 22, with age 27 survey ongoing – opening a natural opportunity to study how the parental behavioral trajectories I model in my dissertation propagate into the next generation, including early labor market outcomes, relationship formation, and the parenting behaviors of the children who are now young adults themselves. This intergenerational extension is a direct and

compelling next step for my research program. The second strand applies reduced-form causal designs – exploiting quasi-experimental variation in state-level welfare reform, incarceration sentencing laws, and parental leave mandates – to produce external validation for the counterfactual predictions of the structural model. The third strand pursues international applications, using the methods developed in my dissertation alongside the household and firm-level data I have worked with through the World Bank Enterprise Survey to study intergenerational transmission of disadvantage in Sub-Saharan African contexts, where fragile family structures are widespread and the policy evidence base is thin.

I am committed to supporting this agenda through external funding. My domestic work on fragile families and child development is well-positioned for support from NIH and NICHD, whose funding priorities directly intersect with questions of family structure, parental behavior, and child health. My international and education work aligns with NSF Economics and IES grant programs. I have prior experience securing competitive research funding – including two Green Fund grants supporting my early work on energy consumption and household behavior – and I view the UNC Dissertation Completion Fellowship I was awarded for 2026/27 as further evidence of the competitiveness of my research agenda. I look forward to building on this foundation as an independent researcher.

Throughout all of this work, my objective is to generate evidence that is both methodologically credible and directly useful to policymakers. The families at the center of my research – disadvantaged, often single-parent households in the United States and in low-income countries – are the families most in need of well-designed policy, and the ones for whom poorly designed policy does the most harm. I am excited by the prospect of contributing to this field as both a researcher and a teacher.